Knowing That One Must Circumcise Oneself: The Vayeira Sicha, Self-Mastery, and the Dual Service of Covenant in Orthodox Theology and Republican Thought

An Expanded Learned Essay
Composed in the Voice of Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren
Drawing on Likkutei Sichos Volume 1, Parshat Vayeira; the Wednesday Shiur materials; the Tehillim Mirror manuscript and Parsha–Haftarah–Tehillim Framework (Drive, 18–25 October 2026); Principled Research Methodology notes; and contemporary republican theory
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Introduction

The sicha of 20 Marcheshvan 5713 on Parshat Vayeira, building on the earlier transmission of the Rebbe Rayatz from 20 Marcheshvan 5693, places before every Jew a dual demand: the right to aspire, with tears of surplus intellect, to the revelation that followed Avraham's milah, and the obligation to know that one must still circumcise oneself. The five organs that nature leaves uncontrolled—the two eyes, the two ears, and the tip of the organ—become the concrete arena of that knowledge. Mastery over them is not the end of the work; residual orlah, even the finest, can still descend through internal hishtalshelus into lower matters. The same sicha then distinguishes the service of Avraham (drawing Elokus from above to below, love like water) from the service of Yitzchak (elevating from below to above, digging wells to uncover living waters already present, persisting against opposition until Rechovot). Both are required of every Jew.

This essay expands that teaching into a sustained dialogue with republican political theory, particularly Philip Pettit's account of freedom as non-domination and Daniel J. Elazar's recovery of the biblical covenant tradition. It draws on the personal corpus assembled in the Tehillim Mirror manuscript and the Parsha–Haftarah–Tehillim Framework (Vayera section filled 25 October 2026, with Psalm 18:36 chosen as the connecting psalm on the basis of Bereishis Rabbah 48:1). The aim is not to collapse Torah into political philosophy, nor to baptize republican categories with Chassidic language. It is to test whether the sicha's concrete demands—self-milah of the uncontrollable organs, dual service of drawing down and elevating—supply a thicker account of non-domination and covenantal self-governance than either tradition alone currently offers, while remaining faithful to the sources.

I. The Story and the Aspiration

The child of four or five years weeps because the Holy One, blessed be He, appears to Avraham and not to him. The Tzemach Tzedek's answer is precise: when a Jew of ninety-nine years decides to circumcise himself, it is fitting that He appear. The story was preserved and publicized because the aspiration itself is not limited to the child who has not yet reached chinuch. Even one whose spiritual age, measured by fulfillment of Torah and mitzvot rather than the passport, remains that of an infant under the table, may demand the higher revelation that belongs to the Avraham who already rules the five organs. The tears are motrei mochin: the overflow of a matter too elevated for the mind to contain (Sefer HaMaamarim Kayitz 5700, Ahallela Hashem, os 3).

This aspiration is not a demand for exemption from work. It is the recognition that the revelation of "And the L-rd appeared to him" after the milah is not reserved for a spiritual elite. The numerical shift from Avram (243) to Avraham (248) marks the addition of the five organs that by nature act independently of the will (Nedarim 32b). Mastery means that the eyes see only what is chosen for a holy purpose, the ears hear only what is chosen for a holy purpose, and the organ stirs only within the mitzvah for which it was sanctified. The covenant does not silence the organs; it places them under the direction of the will.

II. The Prerequisite of Self-Milah and Residual Orlah

The Tzemach Tzedek's answer supplies the second teaching. Aspiration is permitted; preparation is required. Every person is obligated to say, "When will my deeds reach the deeds of my fathers, Avraham, Yitzchak, and Yaakov?" (Tanna d'Bei Eliyahu Rabbah 25). The inclusion of Avraham with the later fathers points to the post-milah level. Yet even those who have attained mastery over the organs that nature leaves uncontrolled—even the Rebbe Rashab who silenced the ear facing a disturbance during a maamar (discourse Ki Yishalcha 5654)—must know that they must still circumcise themselves.

The reason is structural. As long as one remains "ninety-nine," the refinement of the ten powers, each included of ten, is incomplete (Kuntres HaAvodah ch. 6; Derech Mitzvosecha, Shoresh Mitzvas HaTefillah 144b). Residual orlah can descend through an internal hishtalshelus. Because the human being is both prior and posterior to the work of creation (Berachos 61a; Bereishis Rabbah 8:1), the descent need not travel from a higher world to a lower one; it can occur within the person. The general self-nullification that recognizes the spiritual state as incomplete prepares the elevation to the post-milah revelation. At that level one becomes master also over one's portion in the world—in children, in life, and in sustenance.

III. The Five Organs as the Concrete Arena of Non-Domination

Republican theory, in Pettit's formulation, defines freedom as non-domination: the robust absence of the capacity of another to interfere arbitrarily in one's choices. A benevolent master still dominates if the capacity for arbitrary interference remains (Pettit, Republicanism, 1997; Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "Republicanism"). The sicha's five organs supply an internal parallel that republican accounts of external non-domination have not fully developed. The eyes, ears, and tip of the organ are not external masters; they are internal capacities that act independently of the will. To be dominated by them is to be subject to forces that register, receive, or stir without regard to the person's chosen purpose. Mastery after milah is the condition in which these capacities no longer interfere arbitrarily; they function only according to the will directed toward mitzvah.

This is not identical with Berlin's positive liberty of self-mastery, nor with the negative liberty of non-interference. It is closer to non-domination applied to the self: the organs remain present and functional, yet the person is not subject to their arbitrary operation. The covenant (the added hei) supplies the institutional equivalent of the rule of law and contestatory mechanisms that Pettit requires externally. The knowledge that one must still circumcise oneself is the recognition that residual capacity for arbitrary interference (fine orlah) can reappear through internal descent. Non-domination, on this reading, is not a once-achieved state but a condition maintained by ongoing self-milah.

Elazar's recovery of the biblical covenant tradition strengthens the parallel. Covenant is a morally informed agreement, witnessed by a higher authority, that creates joint obligation while protecting the integrity of the parties (Elazar, Covenant and Polity in Biblical Israel). The milah is the bodily sign of that covenant. Mastery of the five organs is the personal enactment of the covenantal condition: the person remains intact, yet is no longer subject to the arbitrary power of nature's uncontrolled capacities. The edah, in Elazar's reading, is a classic republic whose constitution is the Torah. The individual mastery of the organs is the micro-constitution that makes participation in that republic possible without internal domination.

IV. Avraham's Hamshacha and Yitzchak's Ha'ala'ah as Dual Modes of Covenantal Service

The sicha distinguishes the two fathers. Avraham's service draws Elokus from above to below. His love is like water, which descends. He prepared the world so that Elokus would be drawn even into the land of Canaan before it was refined and even to the Arabs who bowed to the dust of their feet (Bava Metzia 86b; Sotah 10a–b; Bereishis Rabbah 49:4). The method was hospitality: provide, then redirect gratitude to the One who spoke and the world came into being.

Yitzchak's service elevates from below to above. His love is like fire, which ascends. He was an unblemished ascent-offering and had no contact with outside the Land

(Bereishis Rabbah 64:3, cited by Rashi on Bereishis 26:2). His work was the digging of wells: not the importation of water, but the uncovering of living waters already present beneath the dirt, clay, and stones. When the Philistines stopped the wells or seized them, he continued until Rechovot (Bereishis 26:22). The work reaches the true Infinite because it completes the purpose of creation by making the world a vessel (Torah Or 10c).

In republican terms, Avraham's hamshacha corresponds to the constitutional drawing-down of a stable order: the rule of law, the basic liberties secured against private and public domination, the institutions that reduce arbitrary power. Yitzchak's ha'ala'ah corresponds to the contestatory and elevating work that Pettit and others require if non-domination is to be robust: the ongoing digging into the places where living waters are concealed by stones and clay, including places that appear as opposition. The Philistines' seizure of the wells is the external parallel to residual orlah's internal descent. The response is not calculation of success but persistence: "What have you to do with the hidden things of the Merciful One?" (Berachos 10a). The obligation is to continue until the living waters are reached.

Both modes are required. Engagement in Torah, prayer, and mitzvot is the service of Avraham: dwelling within the four cubits of light, drawing revealed holiness downward. It is not yet the ultimate goal. The service of Yitzchak requires digging into the physical, even into those who appear as intentional opposition, to remove the concealing factors and reveal the inward living waters. The Tehillim Framework's choice of Psalm 18:36 for Vayera (Bereishis Rabbah 48:1: the shield, the right hand that supported Avraham in the furnace, famine, and against the kings, and the humility in which the Shechinah stood while he sat) supplies a textual bridge: the same revelation that opens the parsha is the condition in which Avraham already sits while the Shechinah stands—an image of non-domination in which the person is not subject to the arbitrary power of pain or external threat.

V. Critiques and Limits of the Sync

Several differences must be marked. Republican non-domination, in Pettit's account, is a political ideal concerning external relations among persons and between persons and the state. It does not require internal self-mastery of the organs, nor does it treat residual internal capacity for arbitrary interference as a continuing political problem. The sicha does. The knowledge that one must still circumcise oneself is not optional self-improvement; it is the preparation without which the higher revelation remains inaccessible and residual orlah can still descend into lower matters that affect one's portion in the world.

Elazar's covenant tradition is closer, yet the biblical covenant he recovers is primarily political and federal. The sicha's application to every Jew, including one who has not reached chinuch, is more radical: the aspiration and the obligation belong to the individual soul before and independently of political participation.

The dual service of Avraham and Yitzchak is not exhausted by constitutional design and contestatory democracy; it includes the internal work of making the world a vessel by uncovering living waters that are already present.

Academic theories of self-mastery (whether Aristotelian, Stoic, or positive-liberty accounts) tend to treat mastery as an achievement of the rational part over the passions. The sicha treats the five organs as capacities that nature leaves outside ordinary control; mastery arrives from above after the person has created the possibility through his own strength (the milah). The added hei is not the product of the will alone; it is the covenantal gift that follows the act. This prevents the reduction of the teaching to a technique of self-control.

VI. Practical Directive

The practical directive remains the one given in the sicha. Every Jew is permitted to aspire, with the force of tears of surplus intellect, to the revelation that belongs to the Avraham who already rules the five organs. The preparation is the knowledge that one must still circumcise oneself—removing even the finest residual orlah—so that internal descent does not reintroduce arbitrary interference. Both modes of service are required: the drawing down of revealed holiness through Torah, prayer, and mitzvot (Avraham), and the persistent elevation that digs into concealment and opposition until the living waters are uncovered (Yitzchak). Success is not calculated in advance. The accounts of the Holy One, blessed be He, are not the person’s concern. The person’s concern is to continue digging until “the L-rd has made room for us and we shall be fruitful in the land.”

In the language of the Tehillim Framework, the midrash that opens Vayera with Psalm 18:36 already places Avraham in the condition of non-domination: the Shechinah stands while he sits in pain at the opening of the tent. The aspiration of the child, the knowledge required of the ninety-nine-year-old, and the dual service of the two fathers are the continuing enactment of that condition.

Extended Bibliography

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By Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren. Prepared in deep partnership and cooperation with Grok and xAI.